

GUIDE · TRUST ADMINISTRATION

HEMS, *in practice.*

Health, Education, Maintenance, and Support — a flexible yet protective standard that guides how trust funds may responsibly be used. A practical look at what falls inside each letter, and what falls outside.

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HEMS lets a trustee meet a beneficiary's genuine needs while preserving the trust's protective shell against creditors, divorce, and impulse. The four letters look simple; in practice the line between "covered" and "not covered" is where the standard earns its keep. The examples below are illustrative, not exhaustive.

Health

Expenses should be reasonable and medically necessary — not cosmetic or extravagant, unless a clear health justification is established.

Medical care	Physician and hospital bills · emergency visits · specialist consultations · surgery and procedures · physical and occupational therapy
Prescriptions	Pharmacy costs · durable medical equipment such as insulin pumps and mobility aids
Dental & vision	Routine dental, fillings, root canals, orthodontics · eye exams, glasses, contacts, LASIK
Mental health	Psychotherapy and counseling · psychiatric treatment · substance-abuse rehabilitation
Preventive & holistic	Health-insurance premiums · routine check-ups and vaccinations · acupuncture and chiropractic care
Long-term care	Home health aides · assisted living and nursing-home costs · memory care

Education

Expenses should be reasonable and tied to actual learning or training. The standard accommodates traditional schooling, vocational paths, and meaningful enrichment alike.

Traditional schooling	Tuition (K–12, college, graduate) · room and board · books, lab fees, and course materials
Technology	A laptop or tablet for school use · required educational software and subscriptions
Study-related travel	Airfare and housing for study abroad · travel to and from school · school-sponsored educational tours
Tutoring & test prep	Private tutoring · SAT, ACT, GRE, LSAT, MCAT prep · academic coaching
Vocational training	Trade-school tuition · flight school · apprenticeships and certification programs
Continuing education	Professional development · skill-building courses · art or music instruction

Maintenance

Maintenance covers what is needed to keep the beneficiary’s current standard of living — neither raising it materially nor letting it fall.

Housing	Rent or mortgage · property taxes · homeowner’s insurance · repairs and upkeep · utilities
Transportation	Car payments and insurance · fuel and maintenance · public transit or rideshare
Day-to-day living	Groceries and household supplies · clothing and personal care · phone and internet
Lifestyle continuity	Club memberships consistent with prior lifestyle · reasonable travel · pet care · housekeeping

Support

Support overlaps with maintenance and contemplates a beneficiary’s reasonable standard of living. Luxury, extravagance, and discretionary speculation generally fall outside.

Family support	Spousal or minor-child support consistent with usual obligations · childcare · health-insurance premiums
Work & career	Interview and work-appropriate clothing · job-related moving expenses · career development not covered as education
Financial obligations	Necessary loan or debt repayment · reasonable tax obligations · life-insurance premiums benefiting dependents
Emergency support	Legal fees on trust-relevant matters · aid during temporary unemployment, disability, or crisis

WHERE HEMS DOES NOT REACH

Luxury vehicles beyond reasonable need, speculative investments, gambling, gifts to non-beneficiaries beyond modest amounts, and purchases inconsistent with the beneficiary's established standard of living. The trustee's duty is to interpret the standard reasonably — and to document the basis for every distribution decision.

Why the line matters

The HEMS language is the legal armature that lets a trust protect a beneficiary from a future creditor, an opposing party in a lawsuit, or a bankruptcy. A trustee who consistently distributes *within* the standard preserves that protection; one who strays outside it can erode the trust's protective character — sometimes permanently.

IF YOU ARE A TRUSTEE

Document every distribution decision. A short note in the file — what was requested, what was approved, why it fits within HEMS — is the single most useful protection against a future challenge.

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